

where Julius was a successful wool merchant—and showed an early talent for music. It was, however, assumed that Fritz would follow in his father's footsteps.

After completing his education in 1880, he worked for the family business in offices in France, Sweden, and Germany. He enjoyed the cultural life of these countries, and also took lessons in music. Still opposed to his son's wish to take up a musical career, his father then sent him to Florida to manage an orange plantation. Undaunted, Fritz continued his studies in the US, and after a year moved to Danville, Virginia, where he made a living teaching music, French, and German and also composed pieces inspired by US popular songs.

The big break

In 1886, despite his father's wishes, Fritz moved to Leipzig to study at the Conservatoire. This gave him the grounding in theory he needed, but his inspiration came from meeting Edvard Grieg, who encouraged the young composer and influenced his early style. Grieg persuaded the family to support Fritz's developing career, and in 1888 he moved to Paris where, with financial help from his uncle, he worked full-time as a composer.

Delius mixed with artists and writers in the city, and it was probably here that he caught syphilis, which plagued his later years; but it was also where he began his relationship with German painter Jelka Rosen. She bought a house in the village of Grez-sur-Loing, just outside Paris, where the couple lived after their marriage in 1903.

Despite his German ancestry and studies in Leipzig, Delius